

Tiv Language Archive

1. Phrases

Category	English / Context	Tiv
Greeting	Welcome	M sugh u za van
Greeting	Hello (General greeting)	M sugh u
Greeting	How are you? (How is your day going?)	U pande nena?
Greeting	How do you do?	U ngu nena?
Greeting	Reply to 'How are you?'	M ngu dedoo, m sugh
Greeting	Long time no see	I chagh igba se kera nenge ga
Question	What's your name?	Iti yo er nyi?
Question	What's your name?	Iti yough er ana?
Statement	My name is ...	Iti yam er ...
Question	Where are you from?	Tar wou ka hana?
Statement	I'm from ...	Tar wam ka...
Greeting	Pleased to meet you	Doom u zuan vea we
Greeting	Good morning	U nder ver
Greeting	Good afternoon	U pander ver
Greeting	Good evening	U pande ver
Greeting	Good night	Yav doo doo
Parting	Goodbye	Saa shie u gen
Parting	Goodbye	Za dedoo
Well-wishing	Have a good journey	Za dedoo
Well-wishing	Good luck!	Ikyôô i lagh u
Well-wishing	Have a nice day	Iyange i doo
Well-wishing	Have a nice meal	Kwaghyan a doo
Affirmation	Yes	Een
Negation	No	Ei

Category	English / Context	Tiv
Uncertainty	Maybe	A doo ga
Understanding	I don't know	Mfa ga
Understanding	I don't like it	Mso ga
Question	Do you understand?	U kav kpa?
Understanding	I understand	M kav
Understanding	I don't understand	M kav ga
Request	Please speak more slowly	We alumum yô, lam kure kure
Request	Please say that again	We alumum yô shi kimbir ôron kwagh la
Request	Please write it down	We alumum yô nger kwagh la shin inyar
Question	Do you speak English?	U lamen dzwa Batur?
Question	Do you speak Tiv?	U lamen dzwa Tiv?
Answer	Yes, a little (reply to 'Do you speak ...?')	Enn, ka mlam chuku
Understanding	I don't speak Tiv	M fa u lamen dzwa Tiv ga
Question	Do you speak a language other than Tiv?	U fa u lamen dzwa u ngen dugh dzwa Tiv sha yô?
Request	Speak to me in Tiv	Lam a mo ken dzwa Tiv
Question	How much is this?	Ishe i kwagh ne ka nena?
Politeness	Sorry	Washima
Politeness	Please	We alumum yô
Appreciation	Thank you so much	M sugh u kpishi
Appreciation	Thank you	M sugh u
Reply	Reply to thank you	Mo kpa u msugh u
Question	Where's the toilet / bathroom?	Ihungwa/kwa ngi/ngu hana?
Transaction	This gentleman will pay for everything	Gum or u dedoo ne una kimbi hanma kwagh
Transaction	This lady will pay for everything	Gum kwase ne una kimbi hanma kwagh
Invitation	Would you like to dance with me?	U soo u vinen amar vea mo?
Question	Do you come here often?	U ve hen hanma shien?

Category	English / Context	Tiv
Expression	I love you	M soo kwagh wou
Well-wishing	Get well soon	Dzua guda fele
Command	Go away!	Yem sha
Command	Leave me alone!	Dem u mlu kwagh wam
Emergency	Help!	Iwasen!
Emergency	Fire!	Usu!
Command	Stop!	De!
Emergency	Call the police!	Yila Daseda!
Greeting	New Year greetings	Ishughun i sha inyom i he

2. Tiv Proverbs

Tiv Proverb	Literal Meaning	Meaning/Application
Alu u kur a ishima i ker ityev u lôhò angbian ruam ga.	If you consider the stress on the farm, you will not invite a brother to eat your food.	No matter how much you suffered to gain wealth or success, you should still care about others and not become selfish.
Hiar ka a hiin i hiin a igbe.	As soon as the whirlwind starts, one starts swearing by the igbe cult emblem.	Conflict should be stopped early before it grows beyond control.
Indyer i tamenor ugen ka ia gba usu we di u mir i you.	When the beard of another old man catches fire, you soak your own with water.	Learn from another person's trouble and take precaution before the same thing reaches you.
Iyongo i hiin a ahan zwa.	Trouble usually starts with laughter.	A joke or insult that looks small can grow into serious conflict.
Ka a fa amar inyumun nga kera numun ga.	When a plan to disrupt a dance festival is uncovered, precaution should be taken to foil the plot.	If the cause of an expected conflict is known, it should be handled early.
Ka a teen we u kpeen ishe.	When you are being sold out, your mar or influence the bargain.	Once you discover a harmful plan against you, act quickly to stop it.
Ka a zaan a za i zaan sha ijô angahar; a geman hidden i hidden a ivaa zwa.	People tiptoe while going on a deal but on their way back wailings are heard.	Secret bad deals often become public when they fail.

Tiv Proverb	Literal Meaning	Meaning/Application
Ka hen ya u orcian-kwagh ka i zua a ikyônogh ki teman ôron ijir i ortavershima ye.	It is in a weak man's house that they find a chair to sit and judge a strong man's case.	Excessive stubbornness or force can make people unite against someone.
Ka wea eren belanda u mkee u kera aan ityô ga.	When you are trading in pepper, you do not scratch your buttocks again.	Be careful in risky situations; your actions should match the reality around you.
Anyi vea nombor je kpa mba zehe.	Even the teeth and the tongue do quarrel sometimes.	Conflict can happen even between close people.
Ivo i nyiman ga kpa ka wea zer a i gbem yô i nyima.	A goat does not bite but when you maltreat it ceaselessly, it bites.	Even a peaceful person may react when pushed too far.
Mngeren ma gbe human tsô ga, saa kwagh ngu a kpe shimin.	Water does not just smell unless something dies inside it.	Every problem has a cause.
Ka a kperan ikpa i ande.	When two people struggle over a bag, it gets torn.	Endless struggle damages what both sides are fighting over.
Kpera keera me tema ka ingyohol ga.	Shift a bit let me also sit does not entail taking over one's seat.	Sharing with someone does not mean losing your ownership.
Mngerem ma acivin ma hie ya ga.	Hot water does not burn a house.	Insults alone should not push a person into violent reaction.
Ishima i waan i ne mkom.	Patience brings about satisfaction.	Patience helps people overcome conflict well.
Ka akor a ou ka a mee iyese i ta u ye.	It is a person's strong appetite for meat that causes the sting of a scorpion.	Desire or greed can lead someone into trouble.
Kwagh kur sha ayem ga.	Running away cannot bring a matter to an end.	Problems should be faced and resolved, not avoided.
Kwagh tse a tsa, kwagh saan ga.	Something may last long but shall surely be over some day.	No conflict lasts forever.
Mba cirin ayem ikyondo ga.	One does not cover up running in a cloth.	Let go of pride and allow peace to happen.
Mba wuan icigh ki sôron bem mba we mkem sha mi ga.	When they are grinding medicine for peace, they do not add pepper to it.	Peace talks should avoid hurtful words and blame.

Tiv Proverb	Literal Meaning	Meaning/Application
Mumu baver cii ve a vie ga.	It is not all corn that must pop before popcorn becomes edible.	Not everybody has to speak before an issue can be settled.
Aluer iyongo i angbianev uhar ngi kuren ga yô, orvanya ka nan ya ve idyako.	When two brothers fight without end, a stranger snatches their inheritance.	Long conflict destroys families and allows outsiders to benefit.

3. Useful Tiv Words / Terms

Tiv	English / Explanation
Anzaakaa	Proverbs (plural)
Injakwagh	Proverb (singular)
Iyongo	Trouble
Ishima	Heart / patience in proverb context
Kwagh	Something / matter / issue (depending on context)
Mngerem / Mngeren	Water
Ivo	Goat
Angbian / Angbianev	Brother / brothers
Mkom	Satisfaction
Orvanya	Visitor / stranger